

TYPES OF CANCER

Throat cancer



THROAT CANCER BOOKLET: EVERYTHING YOU NEED TO KNOW

What is throat cancer?

Throat cancer generally refers to cancers that start in the pharynx or larynx (voice box), but can also refer to cancers that start in the oesophagus (food pipe) or thyroid. Some cancers which begin in the throat area, as well as the tongue, salivary glands, sinuses, nose or ear, are classified as [head and neck cancers](#).

Symptoms

Diagnosis

Treatment

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Understood



The two main types of cancer that are commonly referred to as throat cancers are pharyngeal and laryngeal cancers - cancer of the pharynx and the larynx.

► **PREVENTION**

► **PROGNOSIS**

Throat cancer signs and symptoms

Symptoms for throat cancers can include:

throat pain

shortness of breath

persistent sore throat or cough

coughing up blood

changes to the voice such as hoarseness

difficulties swallowing

feeling there is something stuck in the throat

lumps in the neck or throat

sudden unexplained weight loss

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smoking tobacco

excessive alcohol consumption

human papillomavirus (HPV)

epstein-barr virus (EBV)

poor diet

family history of cancer

Diagnosis of throat cancer

Tests to diagnose pharyngeal or laryngeal cancer may include:

Physical examination

Your doctor will examine your mouth, throat and neck and may insert a gloved finger into your mouth to examine areas that are difficult to see.

Blood tests

Samples may be taken to check your general health.

Biopsy

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A thin tube with a light on its end (endoscope) will be inserted through the nose to look for abnormalities in the throat.

Ultrasound

A small device called a transducer is used to send out soundwaves that echo when they hit something dense such as an organ or tumour.

X-rays

You may have a chest x-ray to check your overall health or to see if cancer has spread to the lungs.

CT scan

A CT (computerised tomography) scan uses x-ray beams to create detailed cross-sectional images of inside your body.

MRI

An [MRI](#) (magnetic resonance imaging) scan uses magnet and radio waves to create detailed images of the inside of your body.

PET scan

A PET (positron emission tomography) scan combined with a CT scan, is often recommended. Radioactive material is injected into the body to help show cancer cells.

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After finding out you have throat cancer, you may experience a range of emotions such as disbelief, confusion and sadness and feelings of loss of control. These reactions are normal and you may find it helpful to talk to family and friends about how you feel.

Talk to your doctor about treatments that are available to you, potential side effects and how soon you should start treatment. Take as much time as you can before making a decision.

Treatment for throat cancer

Treatment will depend on the size of the cancer, whether it has spread and your overall health

Staging

Tests for throat cancers will confirm if you have cancer and how far it has spread. This is called staging and will help your doctors determine the best treatment options for you. Treatments for throat cancers include surgery, radiation therapy (radiotherapy) and chemotherapy, or a combination of one or more of these.

Surgery

Depending on the size of the tumour, you may be recommended [surgery](#) to have it removed. The type of surgery will also depend on the location of the cancer and may involve removing part of the pharynx or the partial or full removal of the larynx,

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After surgery, you may also receive [radiation therapy](#) (also known as radiation therapy). In some cases radiotherapy will be the principal treatment type.

Chemotherapy

In some instances, [chemotherapy](#) may be required along with radiation, particularly if the tumours are large or the cancer has spread to the [lymph nodes](#). Chemotherapy may also be used to shrink tumours prior to surgery.

Treatment Team

Depending on your treatment, your treatment team may consist of a number of different health professionals, such as:

GP (General Practitioner) - looks after your general health and works with your specialists to coordinate treatment.

Ear, nose and throat (ENT) specialist - treats disorders of the ear, nose and throat

Head and neck surgeon - diagnoses and treats cancers of the head and neck.

Oral surgeon - treats disorders of the mouth, face and jaws.

Dentist - evaluates and treats the mouth and teeth

Radiation oncologist - prescribes and coordinates radiation therapy treatment.

Medical oncologist - prescribes and coordinates the course of chemotherapy.

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Dietitian - recommends an eating plan to follow while you are in treatment and recovery.

Pathologist - examines cells and tissues under a microscope

Physiotherapist/occupational therapist - help with physical and practical problems such as restoring movement and mobility after treatment.

Other allied health professionals - such as social workers, pharmacists, and counsellors

Screening for throat cancer

There is currently no national screening program for throat cancers available in Australia.

Preventing throat cancer

Around 60% of pharyngeal and laryngeal cancers in Australia are caused by [smoking](#); around 30% are caused by excess alcohol consumption. So [quitting smoking](#) and [moderating alcohol](#) consumption will significantly reduce your risk of developing throat cancer.

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Your doctor will not be able to predict the exact course of the disease, as it will depend on individual circumstances such as the type of throat cancer you have and how far it has spread, your age, medical history and overall health.

Sources

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